months with a removable cast on the lower part of that arm. The injury I picked up in Durban, though, I'd forgotten about even before I was told it had healed. It's meeting Nelson Mandela on that South Africa trip that I'll always remember.

I'm a father to two boys: it's the biggest responsibility in my life. Here's a man who's been a father to a nation. Meeting Mandela was an opportunity I feel humble to have had. We were based in Durban, where the game against South Africa was going to take place three days later. We got a flight at dawn to take us to Johannesburg and were taken to the offices of Mr Mandela's charity foundation. We were all in our England blazers, there were press and other officials and staff gathered round and the morning was already getting warm. The top man, though, seemed so relaxed, leaning back in his armchair, the sunshine streaming through the window behind him.

Victoria will tell you: I've become used to a bit of public speaking since I got the England armband. A little preparation, along with the self-confidence she's given me, and I'm usually ready to go. In fact, Victoria reckons the difficult bit is getting me to stop making speeches these days. My time came to speak to Mr Mandela. I sat down and leaned in towards him. I had a job to do as England captain but, at first, I was just dumbstruck in his presence, overwhelmed with my respect and admiration for him. Did he pickup on how I was feeling? I don't know, but he put me at ease with a little pat on the back. I remembered some of what I'd wanted to say:

'To meet a great man such as you is an amazing honor. It's great to be here today. It's an amazing honor for all of us.'

Mr Mandela asked me and the other England players to support South Africa's bid to host the 2010 World Cup. I'd love to see them get it: soccer's the people's sport in South Africa. I'd come with United in the past and again, this time with England, you could see the passion for the game all around you: in the stadiums, in the townships, and on every street corner. I gave Mr Mandela an England shirt with his name and 03 on the back. I know he likes team colors: I still remember him wearing the South African rugby shirt after they won the final of the Rugby World Cup. He leaned forward and reached a hand out: some of his grandchildren came up to meet me and the rest of the England lads. He said quietly to them:

'This is David Beckham.'

I had my hair in tight braids and one of the press guys asked Mr Mandela what he thought about it. He just smiled: